Israel: Opposition has more government formation options

送信者: EG Middle East & North Africa 受信日時: 2026-10-24 06:19

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Opposition has more government formation options in tight elections

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The bloc of parties opposed to Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu is favored to form the next government (55% odds), with an unstable minority arrangement supported externally by Arab parties more likely (35%) than a majority government (20%).
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The anti-Netanyahu bloc would likely use its control of the Knesset to pursue major domestic priorities, including restrictions that could effectively bar Netanyahu from retaining power, a state commission of inquiry into the security failure that led to the 7 October 2023 attacks, and the conscription of ultra-Orthodox men.
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Netanyahu has a 45% chance of holding onto power—either through a prolonged caretaker government lasting several months (35%) or a new majority coalition (10%)—and his continued tenure would maintain the risks of major new escalations in Israel’s ongoing regional conflicts.

Opposition has more options to form a government (55% likelihood, down from 60%). The pro- and anti-Netanyahu blocs are running neck and neck in Eurasia Group’s latest average of Israeli election polls, and both blocs remain below the 61-seat Knesset threshold to form a majority government.

Opposition figures Avigdor Lieberman of Yisrael Beiteinu and Naftali Bennett of the Together party have rejected participating in a coalition with Arab parties, reflecting greater sensitivity among Jewish Israelis since the 7 October attack. If this position holds, the opposition’s most likely path to power is a minority government (35%), in which Arab parties provide external support in exchange for greater funding and favorable policies such as improved policing amid rising crime in Arab communities.

Though Lieberman has ruled out a minority government, he wants to remove Netanyahu and would likely accede to this arrangement. A minority government would be relatively unstable and liable to collapse within its first one or two years over sensitive issues such as Israeli policies in the West Bank

and Gaza.

An opposition majority is possible (20%). A strong election performance by the anti-Netanyahu bloc could permit it to reach a majority by bringing on board Mansour Abbas's Arab Ra'am party. Ra'am participated in the Bennett-led government from 2021 to 2022, and Lieberman and Bennett could drop their objections. An alternative would be for the unaligned Reservist-NEP alliance and Ofer Winter's new far-right Amcha Yisrael party to join the anti-Netanyahu bloc if they cross the 3.25% threshold for Knesset representation. Winter had committed to joining a Netanyahu government, but the prime minister has sharply criticized him in recent weeks. The opposition might be able to accommodate his positions in a coalition without Arab parties.

Another, less likely, path to a majority that Lieberman favors would emerge if Netanyahu was forced to step aside after a defeat. Under new leadership, Likud—or enough of its members—could then agree to form a new Zionist Jewish majority. Lieberman, whose party is arguably the most right-wing in the anti-Netanyahu bloc, may believe he is better suited to run such a government than the more moderate former Israel Defense Forces chief of staff Gadi Eisenkot, whose more centrist Yashar party polls as the largest in the opposition bloc.

Another possible scenario would be for the anti-Netanyahu and Arab blocs to use their likely post-election majority to take control of the Knesset speakership before a new government is formed, partly with the aim of removing Netanyahu and eliciting Likud defections. They could pass a series of new laws, potentially including a ban on individuals undergoing criminal trials from holding the premiership; prime ministerial term limits; the creation of a state commission of inquiry into the 7 October attack; and an end to the exemption on ultra-Orthodox conscription. Netanyahu and Likud would object to this arrangement, and the current Likud speaker may refuse to seat the new Knesset to prevent a vote on a new speaker, producing a showdown at the Supreme Court, and if the court's order is ignored, a constitutional crisis. As in similar episodes in the past, however, the sides would most likely reach a compromise.

Netanyahu may still hold on to power (45%, up from 40%). The most likely path is a deadlocked Knesset in which he remains as caretaker prime minister for several months before new elections are held (35%). His bloc would need to substantially overperform to reach a majority (10%).

Likud has outperformed pre-election polls before. It may emerge as the largest party, potentially giving it the first shot at forming the next government. However, the opposition is better structured to maximize its seat count—with more vote-sharing agreements and lower risks of parties that fail to cross the threshold—and may benefit from higher voter turnout.

A government led by the anti-Netanyahu bloc would limit regional escalation. Most of the bloc's parties are comparably hawkish on security to Netanyahu. However, they would likely limit conflicts with some adversaries and reach agreements with others to repair US ties and improve Israel's international standing.

Such a government would be more likely than Netanyahu to reach a deal on Gaza, as well as a new security arrangement with the Syrian government. It would also forgo major annexations in the West Bank and roll back settler violence against Palestinians, which would boost efforts to normalize relations with Arab and Muslim states, including Saudi Arabia.

An anti-Netanyahu bloc-led government would maintain pressure on Hezbollah in southern Lebanon and likely participate in a new round of US-led escalation against Iran. However, it would be less likely than Netanyahu to actively pursue such escalation—jointly with the US or alone with US backing—at least early in its tenure.

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